THE SANDWICH PROJECT

www.TheSandwichProject.org

TSP HOST HANDBOOK

Nourish the Hungry. Feed the Soul.

Welcome to The Sandwich Project Team

Thank you for opening your home to support The Sandwich Project (TSP). You play a critical role in helping us safely deliver fresh food to those in need.

Who We Serve:

People who are unhoused or housing-insecure, children and students, veterans, seniors, and working individuals and families, who may be struggling to afford enough food. Many of the people we serve also face additional challenges, such as health conditions, disabilities, limited access to transportation, and no healthcare insurance.

TIP: You Are Not Alone!

The TSP team will support you throughout the process. You will be assigned to a team with a lead host who can answer your questions.

The Important Role of a TSP Host

We believe in the power of community, kindness, and the fundamental right to nourishment. Our diverse network of volunteers, including hosts, drivers, families, and partner organizations, works together across Metro Atlanta to make this possible.

By providing a convenient drop-off location, you act as the vital connection between individual sandwich makers and the delivery of thousands of sandwiches. **You are the face of The Sandwich Project** - your role is indispensable!

Monthly Vacation Schedules

Each month, a team member will send you a Google Form to record any weeks you will be unavailable to collect.

You will need…

A Collection Area

Choose a designated area accessible to volunteers for collections each Wednesday.

Spare Refrigerator Space

You should have an extra refrigerator (or TSP will assign one to you).

Availability on Wednesdays and on Thursday mornings

Be available on Wednesdays for collection and on Thursday mornings for delivery. TSP will do everything possible to make this fit your schedule.

Materials Provided by TSP

Coolers & Ice Packs

Insulated coolers and reusable ice packs for maintaining temperature during transport.

Collection Site Signage

Signs to help volunteers identify your home as an "official TSP collection location."

Sign-In Sheets

Printed sheets for volunteers to record their names, contact information, and sandwich type and numbers.

TSP Labels

Official labels for volunteers to fill out and attach to their prepared sandwiches (separate PB&J and Deli labels).

Additional Materials:

The Sandwich Project has its own web app! It's easy to get started. Katie will email login information and get you started before your first collection day!

Access at **www.thesandwichproject.org** (click "Core Team Access")

Always keep PB&J and Deli in separate coolers. However, anyone with any food allergies should never consume any TSP sandwiches. They are not safe for people with food allergies.

Wednesday: Collection Day Prep

Put Out Donation Bin

Place in an easily accessible location for fruit and/or snack collections.

Prepare Sign-In Station

Place sign-in sheets, both deli & PB&J labels, and pens on a table near the drop-off area.

Organize Sandwich Labels

Keep deli and PB&J labels separate and readily available.

Place TSP Yard Sign

Position prominently for easy site identification by volunteers.

Check Labels

Date on labels should be no earlier than **Tuesday evening** (**preferably Wednesday**).

Safe Transportation

Remind volunteers to deliver cold sandwiches in **cooler bags with ice packs** to maintain proper temperature during transport.

Weekly Newsletter

Remind your sandwich makers to sign up for our weekly newsletter: host vacation dates, TSP vacation weeks, and other pertinent information.

Wednesday Protocol: Collection & Storage

Volunteer Arrival

Greet volunteers at your sign-in station. A warm greeting helps sandwich makers feel welcome and want to stay connected.

Sandwich Labeling

Volunteers label their sandwiches using the host's provided labels.

Receive and Inspect Sandwiches

Check that sandwiches are sealed, properly labeled, and cold to the touch.

Volunteers Sign In

Volunteers sign in and record sandwich counts and contact information.

Sandwich Refrigeration

Sandwiches are placed in the refrigerator, with enough room for proper airflow.

Thursday Protocol: Delivery & Transport

Ensure Sandwiches are Pre-Chilled

Ensure sandwiches are under 39°F before placing them in a cooler.

Layer Ice Packs between Sandwiches

Place ice packs between sandwich loaves and on top. All sandwich loaves should be in contact with an ice pack.

Pack Cooler Tightly

Tightly packed coolers stay cold more effectively than those with excess space.

Keep in Vehicle Cabin

Transport coolers inside the vehicle cabin, not the trunk, where air conditioning cannot regulate temperatures.

Deliver Promptly

Take coolers straight to the designated destination without stopping on the way.

Refrigerate Immediately

Transfer sandwiches to a refrigerator as soon as they arrive at their destination.

Important Transport Rules

Never Pack a Hot Cooler

Empty coolers stored in hot conditions must be brought inside to cool completely before packing.

Never Put Warm Sandwiches in a Cooler

Sandwiches must be refrigerator-cold (below 39°F) before going into coolers. This is non-negotiable.

Do Not Leave Coolers in Your Vehicle

Packed coolers must **NEVER be left in vehicles**—only for use during active transport.

TSP Use Only

To prevent cross-contamination, coolers used for TSP sandwiches should not be used for any other purpose.

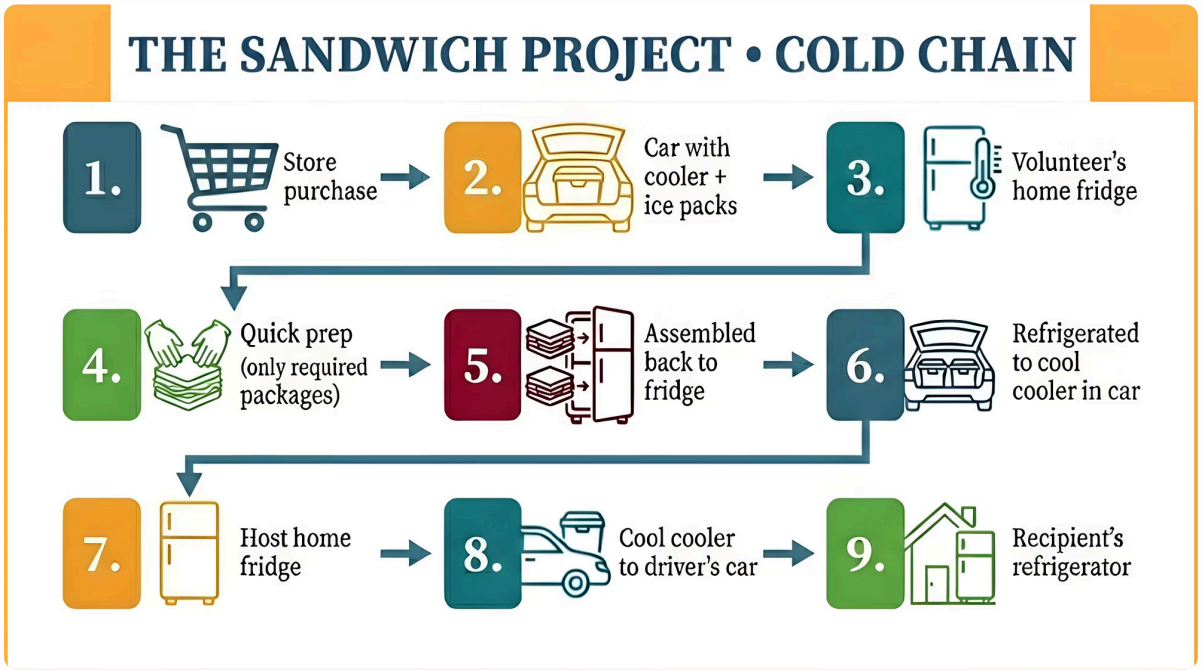
For example, do not use the same cooler for raw meat, fish, or other items.

Close Lids Tightly and Keep Them Closed

Ensure lids are closed quickly after packing and sealed tightly. Leave them closed—the goal is to have the cooler open for as little time as possible.

The Cold Chain

The "cold chain" refers to keeping perishable food consistently cold from the moment it is purchased until it is delivered to the recipient organization.



What do we mean when we say "cold"?

When we say food must stay "cold," we mean refrigerator cold — **below** 39°F.

If the food feels as cold as items in your refrigerator, you are on the right track.

Absolute Temperature Limits

39°F (4°C)

This is the highest safe temperature for deli meat and cheese. Above this temperature, bacterial growth begins.

80°F (27°C)

Deli meat must never reach this temperature.

Food Safety: The Two-Hour Rule

When in Doubt, Throw It Out

Deli meat and cheese may only be above 39°F for a total of two hours, cumulatively. It is NOT "two hours at a time," the time is added up across the entire process from the factory to the consumer of the sandwich.

The Legal Standard

Perishable foods (deli meat/cheese) must stay **below** 39°F (4°C).

After **2 hours altogether** above that, bacteria reach unsafe levels

Re-cooling **does not** kill the bacteria that have already grown.

Why It Matters Even More

As an organization, we are subject to **food safety laws.**

Our recipients are **more vulnerable** to food-borne illness than the average population. For this reason, we must keep sandwiches and ingredients out of refrigeration for as little time as possible.

Two hours may sound like plenty of cushion, until you consider all the steps along the way during which our ingredients might not be kept cold:

While shopping: pick up your ingredients after you've shopped.

During sandwich-making: take out only one package of meat and cheese at a time.

During transfer to and from coolers: move quickly and keep doors and lids closed as much as humanly possible.

Critical: TSP serves children, seniors, people who are sick or immunocompromised, and others at higher risk of foodborne illness, many of whom have limited access to healthcare.

Food Safety: Refrigeration

Temperature Range

Refrigerators must consistently maintain a temperature between **34°–38°F**.

Air Circulation

Adequate air circulation is essential for the refrigerator to actually cool its contents. Do not block fans.

Never Overfill

Overfilled refrigerators can compromise airflow and create warm spots, compromising food safety.

Door Discipline

Refrigeration should remain closed at all times except for brief access to add or remove sandwiches or ingredients, as temperatures rise quickly, especially in hot weather.

Freezer Use

To make sandwiches extra cold for hot-weather distribution, the freezer may be used briefly—limit to 15–20 minutes.

Coolers Are Not Refrigerators

Coolers keep cold food cold—coolers do not cool warm food. They preserve cold temperatures but do not lower them.

Unlike coolers, **refrigerators** actively circulate cold air to lower food temperatures.

Handling Quality Issues

Open/Torn Bags

Transfer sandwiches to a new bag if the outer bag is torn. Ensure the sandwiches themselves are still properly sealed and intact.

Missing/Incorrect Labels

Ask the volunteer to complete the TSP label. Verify the sandwiches were made in the last 24 hours.

Food Safety: Coolers & Transport

Coolers Work For:

Getting sandwich ingredients home from the grocery store.

Transporting pre-chilled sandwiches packed tightly with ice packs.

Properly packed coolers can maintain safe temperatures for up to one hour during active transport.

Coolers DO NOT Work For:

Bringing the temperature of **warm food** down.

Storing cold food for **long periods of time**.

Making warm food **safe again** by **recooling**.

Maximizing Cooler Performance & Safe Transport

Pack quickly

To keep warm air out, coolers should be packed quickly and closed between trips to the refrigerator for loaves. Keep your cooler in the shade while packing, too!

Plenty of Ice Packs in Contact with All Sandwiches

Place ice packs/sheets between layers of sandwiches and on top before closing the lid.

Pack Full with Minimal Free Space

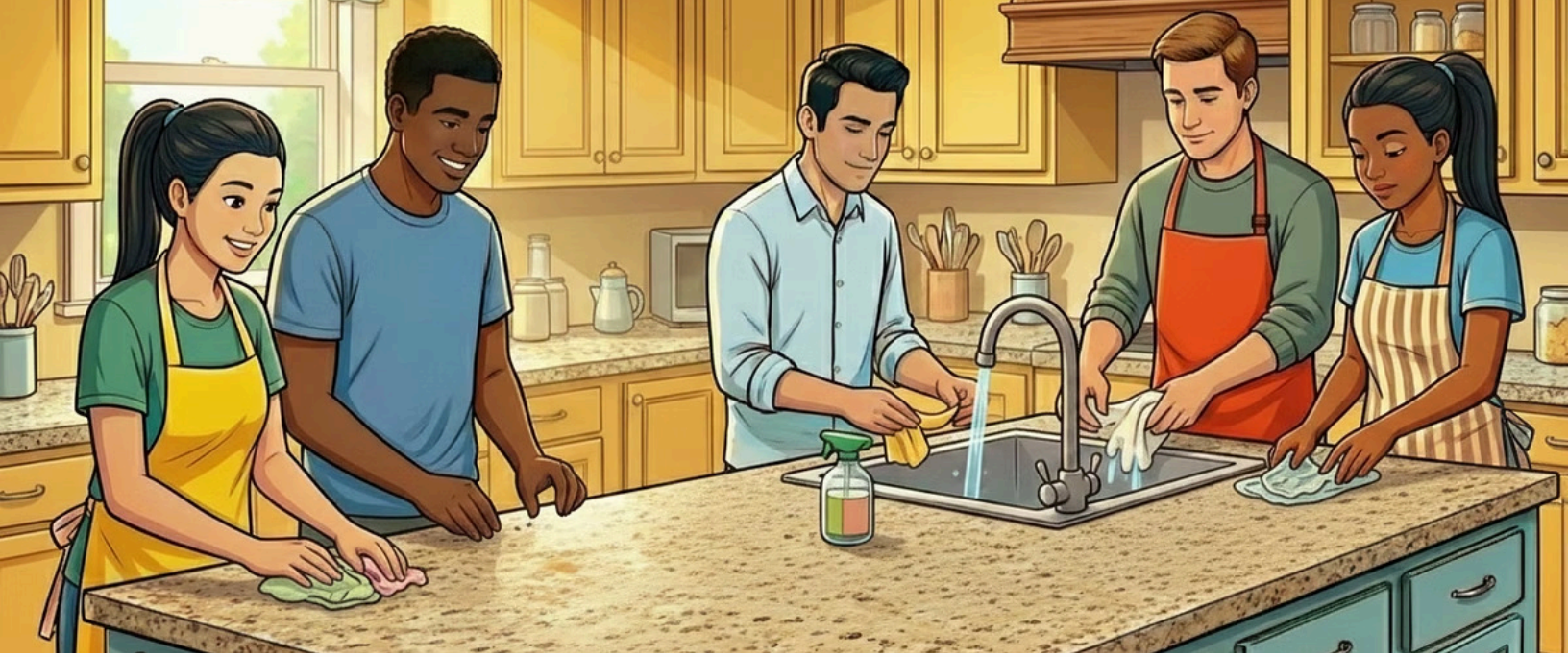
Coolers with minimal air space stay colder longer than partially filled ones.

Keep Lid Closed Tightly

Every time you open a cooler, warm air enters. Do not open coolers during transport.

No Coolers in the Trunk

Keep coolers in the vehicle cabin where A/C circulates, never in the trunk, which lacks airflow and heats up quickly. Trunks can reach extreme temperatures, creating a high-risk environment for perishable food.



Food Safety: Hygiene Standards

Coolers

Wash coolers with soap and warm water after use.

Allow coolers to fully air-dry before storing. Once dry, cover tightly.

Use only dedicated TSP coolers for sandwiches.

Never pack food in a warm cooler. Bring the cooler inside to cool down, and add ice packs to lower the temperature further.

Refrigerator

Clean refrigerator regularly.

Remove all personal food items.

Strictly limit the amount of time the door is open.

When moving sandwiches from fridge to cooler, stay in the shade.

Garage / Collection Area

Keep the collection area clean, uncluttered, and free of strong odors.

Store all food, coolers, and ice packs **off the floor.**

Keep food away from pets, trash, chemicals, and tools.

Food Safety: Shopping and Storage Standards

Use Packaged Deli Meat/Cheese Only

Never use products sliced at the deli counter.

Bring a cooler with ice packs to the store, park in the shade, and place ingredients in coolers for the ride home. Do not make any stops; go straight home.

Two-Week Maximum

Use all unopened meat/cheese **within 2 weeks of purchase,** regardless of the expiration date.

Check Expiration Dates

"Use by" date must be **at least 7 days** after drop-off.

TSP Accepts Only Unopened Sandwich Ingredients

Sandwich makers with leftover ingredients may drop them off at a host home. We will donate them to groups who would like to make more sandwiches than their budget allows.

Discard any donated meat in an open package, including meat left over from events.

Food Safety: Sandwich Prep/Assembly

Clean Surfaces

Clean counters and wash utensils. Store personal items out of reach. Cover your table/counter with a disposable tablecloth for easy cleanup.

Hair Restraint

Tie back hair (including bangs) or use a hairnet; use beard nets for facial hair. Do this before handwashing.

Handwashing

Wash hands with soap and water before starting prep work, during as necessary, and after all prep work is complete in preparation for sandwich making.

Hand sanitizer is unsafe for food handling, as alcohol residue can transfer to gloves and food, and it does not remove all bacteria, food residue, or contaminants.

Food-Safe Gloves

After surfaces and hands are clean and hair is restrained, put on **food-safe gloves,** and do not touch anything other than food ingredients. Change gloves after touching anything other than your sandwich ingredients.

Remember that two-hour rule?

Keep extra meat/cheese packages in the refrigerator.

Only have one package out during sandwich assembly.

Assemble one loaf, then refrigerate it before starting the next. This maintains the cold chain.

After Assembling Your Sandwiches

1. Place each finished sandwich into an individual sandwich-size bag.
2. Remove excess air and seal the sandwich bag completely.
3. Return sealed sandwich bags to their original loaf bag.
4. Securely close the loaf bag using the original twist tie.

- **Do not discard twist ties.** Twist ties are required to keep loaf bags tightly closed.

Food Safety: Labels & Compliance

Label Requirements

Use only TSP-issued labels (may be printed from the TSP app).

After receiving sandwiches, make sure labels match the kind of meat the sandwiches contain.

Fill out all required information.

Time Limits

Sandwiches must be **consumed within 36 hours** of the date made (see label).

Spoilage

Bread and sandwich ingredients should appear fresh and free from mold or other spoilage.

Not all spoilage is visible or detectable by smell, so careful handling is essential.

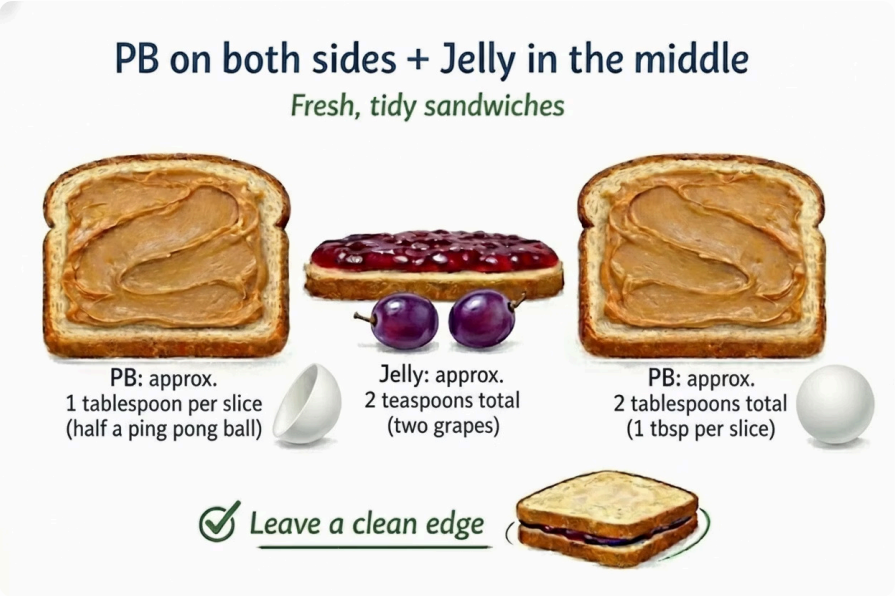
Do Not Accept Warm/Spoiled/Messy Sandwiches

"Quarantine" Problem Sandwiches

1. Isolate them immediately. Mark the bags clearly with "**DO NOT USE**" and a brief reason (e.g., "**WARM**," "**OPEN BAG**," "**UNSAFE**").
2. Contact your lead host for urgent instructions on disposal.

The most important thing to remember is that The Sandwich Project serves our neighbors who are experiencing food insecurity, with a focus on dignity, nourishment, and meeting people where they are.

Visual Reference Standards



PB&J Sandwich Standards

PB: Spread 1 tablespoon on one slice of bread and 2 tablespoons on the other.

Jelly (no jam): Spread 2 teaspoons on one slice on top of peanut butter.

Neatly press both slices together ensuring no peanut butter or jelly oozes out onto the sides.

Deli Sandwich Standards

Cheese: One slice **per side** (2 slices per sandwich)

Meat: Use at least 2 ounces per sanwich (follow the serving size on your product packaging).

No lettuce, tomato, or condiments

Driver Guidelines

Vehicle Release Form

All drivers must sign the **Vehicle Release Form** before their first delivery. Contact Jordan (Driver Coordinator) at 770-789-7329 if you have not received one.

Non-Profit Organizations Only

We deliver exclusively to **501(c)(3) organizations**. We cannot hand sandwiches directly to individuals.

Drivers Are Our Eyes and Ears at Pickup and Dropoff

It is **critical** to report the following issues to Marcy immediately:

- **Unsafe Conditions:** Any recipient location that appears unclean or unsanitary.
- **Improper Storage:** If recipient organizations do not immediately refrigerate the food upon delivery.
- **Inadequate Refrigeration:** If the recipient does not have sufficient cooling capacity to store the food safely.

Contact Information

TSP Team Contacts:

Driver Coordinator: Jordan | **770-789-7329**

Web App & More: Katie | **770-789-1013**

Executive Director: Christine Cooper Nowicki | **(404) 786-8116**

Safety Committee & Co-Founder | Marcy **(678) 596-9697**

Website: thesandwichproject.org

Email: info@thesandwichproject.org

Your Lead Host:

Name: _____

Phone #: _____

Email: _____